



Score Board

Ultra-Portable Laptops Category

Brand	Model	Basic Specifications	Score (Out of 100)	Price (Rs)
Acer	TravelMate 381TCi	Pentium M 1.5 GHz, 512 MB, Intel 855, 12.1-inch, 60 GB, External FireWire Combo Drive, 802.11g, 10/100 Mbps, 2.08 Kg	58.31	84,999
ACI	Ethos Lite	Pentium M 1.7 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 12.1-inch, 40 GB, External USB Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 2.14 Kg	60.34	59,999
Fujitsu	LifeBook S2020	Athlon XP-M 2100+, 256 MB, ATI IGP 320M, 13.3-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, 10/100 Mbps, 1.90 Kg	66.09	80,000
Toshiba	Portégé M100	Pentium M 1.4 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 12.1-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 1.98 Kg	54.14	99,900
Zenith	Presidio VU (MW12)	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 12.1-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 1.95 Kg	62.75	70,000

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drive—all the others had 4,200 rpm drives. On the graphics front, only the Fujitsu LifeBook S2020 came with the ATi IGP 320M graphics chipset; the others had the vanilla Intel Extreme Graphics 2, which is a decent solution when you limit usage to presentations, movies and office applications.

The Acer and ACI models came with external optical combo drives—the Acer had a FireWire drive, the ACI a USB one; the other laptops came with inbuilt combo drives.

It is important to note that in this category, an external drive grants greater flexibility. By not integrating an external drive into the device, the laptop can be smaller; you are granted the freedom to only use it when needed. Thus, the Acer was the lightest laptop tested at 1.66 kilograms, followed closely by the ACI at 1.72 kgs.

Notably, the Zenith Presidio VU had an inbuilt swivel Web camera, ideal for ad-hoc video-conferences. Also worth noting was that the Toshiba lacked a touchpad, which made navigation a torture.

Usability

As pointed out earlier, the Acer and ACI models were the smallest and the lightest, thanks to their external optical drives. For those who will always require an optical drive, the Fujitsu offered the best portability. One negative about external drives is that they occupy a port while in use.

Speaking of ports, the Fujitsu's ports are not placed all that well, but the device made amends with its touchpad and keyboard, which we found to be the best to work with in this class. We found the

build quality of the Toshiba to be the best. The Acer had an unconventional, round touchpad and a small keyboard. The Zenith featured a touchpad whose feel was worse than the feel of the surrounding surface, and the touchpad keys were tacky to boot. The Toshiba did not feature a touchpad at all, going for a pointing stick instead.

All these laptops came bundled with Windows XP Professional, with the exception of the Zenith Presidio VU, which came without an OS.

Only the Fujitsu came with a complete software package, which included a recovery disk, RecordNow—which is CD-burning software, Norman Virus Control and Cyberlink PowerDVD 4. It skipped the driver CD, though. The Toshiba Portégé M100 made system restoration easier by providing a restore DVD instead of multiple CDs.

Acer TravelMate 381TCi



Performance

When we put these laptops through the Winstone suite of tests, the Toshiba Protégé M100 scored the highest at 19.4.

Surprisingly, the ACI Ethos Lite with a 1.7 GHz Intel Pentium M processor could only manage 9.5, which is a very low score.

We encoded a video file to determine the muscle of the processors. Here, the Zenith Presidio VU took just 217 seconds to encode our VOB file to AVI. The ACI was once again the slowest, at 287 seconds.

The Zenith will offer you the best frame rates if you plan on watching movies while in transit. The ACI did do well in the synthetic SiSoft Sandra 2005 CPU test, which tests the CPU in isolation, a scenario that is hardly practical.

The Zenith Presidio VU has an inbuilt swivel Web camera, ideal for ad-hoc video conferences

As we noted before, a fast hard drive goes a long way in improving your computing experience. The Toshiba M100 with its 5,400 rpm drive was certainly the fastest, logging an impressive 32 MBps as the drive index and offering an access time of just eight ms, which is usually in the range of 10-12 ms. Applications will launch faster, and data will be saved and backed up faster on this laptop.

While you might not play games on these machines, gaming scores reflect the capabilities of the video card, and are important if you are a CAD/CAM designer or an architect.

In *Call of Duty*, an OpenGL game, the Acer 381TCi gave the highest frame rates of 25.3 fps at 800 x 600. In *Half-Life 2*, a DirectX game, the Fujitsu S2020 with its Athlon XP-M processor and an ATi IGP320 chipset returned the highest scores of 15 fps and 12.22 fps at 800 x 600 and 1024 x 768 respectively.

While testing viewing angles, all the screens offered readable text from angles as high as 160 degrees, with the Toshiba going as high as 170 degrees. For movies, however, the Toshiba was visible within a range of 130 degrees, whereas the Fujitsu offered 150 degrees. When tested in daylight, except for the Toshiba M100, the others were too dark to be readable.

When it came to battery life, the Zenith Presidio and the Acer 381TCi went 170 minutes on a full charge, which is as good as it gets for an ultra-portable. The Fujitsu, with a 100-minute battery



Toshiba Portégé M100